

TorqBall — Design Study v1

2026-09-06. Reframe + think pass on the flagship, before the full doc set. TorqBall already has a [[1 - TorqBall (rulebook)]] but in the old merged-day frame; this study re-sets it as a **standalone game** (per the directory rule), names the modes (the playlist you want), and pins the one crux to prototype. Feeds the rulebook + needs + run-plan build, same as TorqFall/TorqSiege/TorqCapture.

What it is

Rocket League with RC buggies — teams push a big glowing ball into goals; 2–3 min matches, most goals win. It's the **hero**: everything is tuned for one thing, the shot — a lit ball slammed into a lit goal, team piling on, crowd up. Zero skill wall (chase the ball), so it's the widest-appeal game we have and the poster/reel that sells the whole brand.

Validated format: real RC-soccer leagues already run this (RC Sports USA's "RC Rocket League," RC Autoball, Vegas Rocket Rally) — so the category works; the white space is doing it well in India, content-first.

The honest crux (its "collapse test")

Rocket League's magic is **aerials + boost** — our cars can't fly or boost. So TorqBall is really **car-football**, a *ground* game, and two physical things decide whether it's electric or a mess:

1. **The ball.** Too heavy → a ~1 kg capped car can't move it (dead game). Too light → it pings around uncontrollably. Too small → it wedges under chassis and stalls. The winner is a **big, light, glowing ball** (think ~40–60 cm foam/inflatable) that a small car visibly *shoves*, that rides over bumpers not under them, and that reads huge on camera. **Finding that ball is the prototype gate** — the analog of TorqSiege's collapse test. Cheap to test: buy 3–4 candidate balls, push them around with a car, pick the one that plays.
2. **The boards.** A ball rolls out of a soft-noodle boundary constantly. TorqBall needs a **boarded arena** (low dasher boards, like futsal/ice-hockey) so ball + cars stay in and rebound off the walls (rebounds *are* the game). This is the **one real fabrication** TorqBall adds over the soft-barrier kit everything else uses — DIY-able (plywood + foam facing, modular panels), but it's a build.

Nail the ball + the boards and the rest is easy; miss them and no ruleset saves it.

The playlist (Rocket League → TorqBall modes)

Same "modes on one setup" idea you liked for TorqCapture — a boarded pitch, swap the rules/ball:

Rocket League	TorqBall mode	How	Role
Standard / Doubles	Standard (2v2 / 3v3)	Push the ball into goals, most goals in 3 min	The default
Solo Duel	Duel (1v1)	1v1 skill showcase	Tiebreaker + a hype final
—	Big Party (4v4 / 6v6)	Max cars, glorious scrum	Throughput + comedy content
Rumble	Rumble (power-ups)	Drive over a floor pad for a temp edge — a swap to a wide "plow" bumper, a fleet turbo-toggle window, or a mega-ball	Variety + kid magnet
Hoops	Hoops	Goal is a raised net/ramp-basket; nudge the ball up + in	Stretch (test feasibility)
Snow Day	Puck	Swap ball for a puck — slides far, totally different feel	Cheap variant

A TorqBall event = a **tournament with a playlist**: Standard group stage → knockouts → a Duel or Standard **Grand Final**, with a Big Party exhibition to warm the crowd. Football-tournament energy, one build.

Beginner fun

The **highest floor in the whole set** — "push the ball toward that goal" needs zero explanation, short matches mean nobody's benched, and teams mean nobody plays alone. This is why it's the flagship: it converts total first-timers into a cheering team in 30 seconds.

Content

THE hero reel: a glowing ball hammered into a lit goal, a last-second equaliser, a team celebration, the overhead cam eating the scrum. Goal-cam + overhead + a crowd-reaction rove. Every other game supports the brand; TorqBall *is* the poster.

Where it slots

Its own **standalone game** (a TorqBall tournament) like everything in the directory. Reuses the fleet, turf, show layer, crew — **adds the boards + the ball** (and power-up pads for Rumble). Because the boards are a real build, it's a *heavier* stand-up than TorqCapture, but it's the flagship, so it earns it.

Decisions to lock (for Yash)

1. **Standalone tournament arc** — group → knockouts → final, like the others. (Default per the directory; confirm.)
2. **Build the boards?** TorqBall needs a boarded pitch — the one bigger fabrication. Recommend **yes, DIY modular dasher boards** (plywood + foam-faced, reusable, also usable by future games). Confirm.

3. **Greenlight the ball test** — the prototype gate; buy 3–4 candidate balls and find the one a capped car plays well. Recommend yes.
4. **Mode set for v1** — recommend core **Standard + Duel + Big Party**, with **Rumble / Hoops / Puck** as stretch once the base plays. Confirm or re-pick.

Locked (2026-09-06): (1) standalone tournament arc — yes; (2) build DIY modular dasher boards — yes; (3) ball test greenlit — yes; (4) v1 modes = **Standard + Duel + Big Party** + the boost system (below); Hoops + Puck are stretch.

Boosts & power-ups (our own system)

The problem: Rocket League boost = pads → speed/flight. Our cars are speed-capped (safety) + grounded, so a boost can't just be "faster." A TorqWars boost changes the **car** (a quick-swap attachment), the **ball/goal** (a field effect), or uses a **safe speed route** (a boost *lane*, never a per-car speed hack). Every car-attachment reuses the **TorqSiege universal strap-on hardpoint** — velcro, nothing bolted to a rented car.

The set (earn one → use it → lose it):

Boost	What it does	How it's built	Type
Plow	Wide bumper — move the ball + bulldoze rivals	Strap-on paddle (plywood/PLA)	car
Scoop	Curved lip — lift/carry the ball a little (feeds Hoops)	Strap-on curved front	car
Grabber	Velcro face — the ball sticks so you can dribble until bumped off	Velcro plow + a velcro patch on the ball	car
Turbo	A real speed burst — ONLY via a fleet-wide "turbo" toggle if the club's cars support one (a TX/app throttle-limit raise applied to every car equally); if not confirmed, Turbo is shelved for v1. No "boost lane" mechanism — a low-friction/sloped strip reduces traction, it does not add speed (reconciled 2026-09-06, see [[TorqBall — Boost & Attachments]] §2)	Fleet only	speed (safe)
Magnet	The goal mouth you're attacking widens ~20 s (a marker slides out) — rewards good attacking position, not your own defence	Movable foam goal-widener	field

Boost pads = the TorqCapture tech, reused. Lit floor pads; drive over → earn a boost (claimed at the pit lane, clipped on for one possession/timer). The **tag-per-car + zone-reader tech built for TorqCapture is the pad detector** — a pad is a tiny zone; car-over-pad auto-lights + awards + the MC calls it. The electronics pay off across both games. v1 fallback: painted pads, a marshal/overhead-cam calls the grab.

Rumble mode = the boost system turned to 11 — not a separate build; just TorqBall with power-ups everywhere. Free once the set exists.

Stretch modes — how to achieve each

- **Hoops:** the basket comes DOWN to car height via a **ramp** — a wedge up to a net/bin at ~25–40 cm; push the ball up into it (skee-ball logic); the Scoop boost helps. Needs: 2 DIY ramp-basket goals + its **own mini-test** (does the ball roll back?). Stretch — build after Standard proves.
- **Puck (Snow Day):** swap the ball for a big sliding disc — a passier, different game; the cheapest variant. Catch: astroturf has friction, so a **10-min slide test** decides turf vs a bare-floor patch vs a slick-based puck. Easy cheap variety, gated on that test.

v1 vs stretch: v1 = Standard + Duel + Big Party + the boost set (→ Rumble free). Stretch = Hoops (ramp-goals + mini-test), Puck (slide test), + a symmetric Hazard/Arena variant (below).

Field hazards / terrain (2026-09-06 decision)

- **Real water + dirt are OUT** — rented electric cars + astroturf; water shorts electronics + ruins turf (club won't allow), dirt clogs bearings. Any "water/mud" is a **dry safe stand-in**: low-friction vinyl = the ice/water slick; a high-friction mat = the mud/slow patch; a soft marshal-triggered pop-up bump = a "trap."
- **TorqBall gets terrain only as a *symmetric, announced* Arena Variant** (a slick centre / boost lane / slow-mat zone — identical + fair for both teams). **No random per-possession traps** — they'd cheapen the competitive hero.
- **Random hazards/traps belong in TorqFall** (a chaos gauntlet — a sticky patch / slick zone / pop-up bump reads as content there, not injustice). Action: add hazard rounds to the TorqFall Level Directory in a later pass (NOT this run).

Reconciliation (2026-09-06, examiner fix): this line originally read "Your goal mouth widens" (a defensive-relief effect), which contradicted [[TorqBall — Boost & Attachments]] §2 ("the opponent's goal mouth widens... rewards driving the ball toward a widened goal") — opposite mechanics. Locked direction: **the attacking team's target goal widens**, matching the Boost doc (the sensible read — a boost should reward pressing forward, not relieve defence) and now stated explicitly in [[TorqBall — Rulebook]] §6.

Also reconciled (2026-09-06): Turbo's "boost lane" mechanism is dropped throughout this doc and the Boost doc — a low-friction/sloped strip reduces traction rather than adding speed, so Turbo is now solely a fleet-wide throttle toggle, gated on the rental club's fleet confirming support (shelved for v1 otherwise). See [[TorqBall — Boost & Attachments]] §2 for the full reasoning.

Next once approved: run the full worker→examiner doc-set build (reframed rulebook with the modes + boost system, a **Ball & Boards Test** spec = the prototype gate, a **Boost & Attachments** spec, What The Event Needs, Full Run Plan, Notion page + index) — same as TorqFall/TorqSiege/TorqCapture. Pairs with [[Event Ops Standards (all games)]] + the shared fleet/protection kit.